(Cambodia), who was invited by the Japanese emperor for the consecration of the great Buddha statue at Nara. He is credited with writing down the rituals for the ceremony and composing the sacred music. (Several Buddhist kingdoms in South East Asia retained Brahmin priests for their court and religious rituals, and one sees this practice even today in Thailand.) Bodhisena's musical score is still preserved in the royal palace, and the music is performed once a year by royal musicians. It is known as *gugaku* (ancient music) and a trained Indian ear can discern that it is based on the classical Carnatic raga Mohanam, whose north Indian version is known as Bhupali. Even today the Koreans celebrate an Indian princess who married a royal ancestor. The Buddhist heritage continues to generate a strong affinity for India in these countries.

Our ancient and rich seaborne trade with these nations is seeing a contemporary revival. Today the Asia-Pacific region is the most dynamic component of India's external economic relations, whether in terms of trade, investment or tourism. India is beginning to reconnect with Asia.

Central Asia too was once part of India's extended neighbourhood, and the string of Buddhist monasteries that flourished along the caravan routes over several centuries is testimony to this. These routes traversed some of the highest mountain ranges in the world – the western Himalayas and the forbidding expanses of the Karakoram range. Despite its difficult terrain, remoteness and generally inhospitable environment, this mountain zone has nurtured extraordinarily rich and culturally diverse communities, constituting a veritable ethnic mosaic. The Uighurs, Uzbeks, Tajiks, Kirghiz, Kazakhs and Afghans who travelled along these caravan routes mingled with pilgrims, traders and adventurers from both India and China. These communities have for centuries inhabited the fertile valleys and oases that dot this mountain zone. Ancient trade and pilgrimage routes also criss-crossed the length and breadth of this immense cluster of the world's highest peaks. The myriad communities who call this land their own have long coexisted with one another. Empires and powerful states may have put markers all over this region, staking their claims and demanding allegiance, but the region has been throughout history a zone of shifting political tides,